Alexander von Humboldt



Known as the “founder of plant geography,” Humboldt also made valuable contributions to geology, meteorology, and zoology. Born in Berlin in 1769, he started collecting plants, shells, and insects at an early age. His expedition to Latin America in 1799–1804 encompassed Mexico, Cuba, Venezuela, Colombia, and Ecuador, and his team broke the world altitude record when they climbed to 19,285ft (5,878m) on Chimborazo.

Humboldt also speculated that volcanoes result from deep subterranean fissures, investigated the decrease in temperature with altitude, and discovered that the strength of Earth’s magnetic field decreases away from the poles. The 23-volume work detailing his expedition set a new standard for scientific writing, cementing his fame.

Key works

1807 *Essay on the Geography of Plants*

1805–1829 *Personal Narrative of Travels to the Equinoctial Regions of the New Continent During Years 1799–1804*

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